

The property manager's guide to handling mould

A practical playbook for every mould report, from the first email to a closed file.

14%

21%

29%

Respond

Record

Read

Remediate

Review

Start here: mould is a moisture problem

Every mould report is really a moisture report. Mould needs three things to grow: moisture, something to feed on, such as plasterboard, timber, paint or dust, and time. Take the moisture away and the growth has nothing to work with.

Three ways moisture gets in

A water event

A leak, a burst flexi hose, an overflowing gutter, a roof failure or failed shower waterproofing.

The building

Condensation on cold walls and windows, poor ventilation, exhaust fans that don't vent outside, rising damp or poor drainage.

How the home is lived in

Clothes dried inside, windows kept closed, fans not used, furniture pushed hard against external walls.

Same-looking patch, three different fixes. A photo shows the growth. It doesn't show which pathway you're dealing with.

Where it usually shows up

- Bathroom ceilings, sealant and grout
- Behind wardrobes, beds and couches on external walls
- South-facing bedrooms that rarely see the sun
- Window frames, tracks and sills
- Laundries, especially with indoor drying
- Ceilings below roofs, gutters and upstairs bathrooms

Why it lands on your desk

The owner

An asset that can deteriorate, costs that grow with time, and a relationship that depends on how it's handled.

The tenant

A right to a home that's fit to live in, and the option of NCAT if repairs don't happen.

The insurer

Policies that may exclude mould or look closely at maintenance history.

You

The calls, the emails, the file, and the question of what was done and when.

How a small patch becomes a big job

Minor

A surface patch in one spot, reported early. The scope is usually small.

Moderate

Growth spreading across surfaces, often with a musty smell.

Major

Several rooms, damaged contents or a history of water damage.

Minor becomes major when the process stalls. The 5 R's on the next page are how you keep it moving.

One process for every mould report: the 5 R's

Mould reports arrive on busy days. A fixed process takes the judgement calls out of the moment: the same five steps, in the same order, every time.

1

Respond The same day

Acknowledge the report in writing, ask the triage questions and get any active water stopped.

2

Record Within 24 hours

Dated photos, the condition report, a log entry and a factual brief to the owner.

3

Read Within the week

A professional assessment with moisture and humidity readings and a written report.

4

Remediate Once approved

Fix the moisture source and remove the growth properly, running both in parallel.

5

Review After the works

Close the file, give the tenant the prevention checklist and add mould to routine inspections.

Why the order matters

Each step leaves a record, and each record protects someone: the owner's asset, the tenant's home and your file. Skipping ahead, for example remediating before the water is stopped, is where most repeat callouts begin.

1

Respond

The same day

- **Acknowledge in writing, today.** The clock, and the file, start with your first reply.
- **Water first, mould second.** If it's linked to an active leak, burst pipe, roof or drain, get the plumber or roofer moving now. It may be an urgent repair.
- **Tell the tenant what not to do.** No bleach, dry scrubbing, household vacuuming, fogging or painting over it. These can spread the problem and hide its extent.

The triage questions

- 1 Where exactly is it, and how big? Ask for a photo with a hand in shot for scale.
- 2 How long has it been there? Did it appear suddenly or build up?
- 3 Is anything wet, stained, dripping, soft or bubbling?
- 4 Is it under a bathroom or roof, or on an external wall?
- 5 Is there a musty smell?
- 6 Do the exhaust fans work, and are they being used?

Escalate the same day if

- Water is still getting in
- A ceiling is sagging or a stain is spreading
- Growth covers more than about 1 m²
- Babies, elderly people or anyone with a respiratory condition lives there
- Mould has come back after cleaning
- There's a musty smell but no visible growth

Your first reply to the tenant

"Hi [name], thanks for letting us know about the mould in the [room]. We've logged it today. So we can act quickly, could you send three photos: a close-up, the whole wall or ceiling, and one with your hand in shot? Please also let us know if you've noticed any leaks, stains or musty smells. In the meantime, please don't clean, bleach or paint over it. We'll be in touch by [day] with next steps."

2

Record

Within 24 hours

- **Log it** in your maintenance system with the date and time the report arrived.
- **Keep the tenant's photos and add your own:** a close-up, a wide shot and one with scale.
- **Check the ingoing condition report** and the last routine inspection for any notes on damp or mould.
- **Brief the owner within 24 hours** with facts, not conclusions: photos, the triage answers and what you've already done.

Your first brief to the owner

"Hi [name], your tenant at [address] reported mould in the [room] today. Photos are attached. They've noticed [triage answers], and we've [actions taken]. We recommend a professional assessment so we're working from readings rather than guesses. It gives you the extent, moisture readings and a firm scope before any money is spent on works. Are you happy for us to arrange it?"

Photos show where the mould is. Readings show where the moisture is. A professional assessment turns a disagreement into a document.

What a proper assessment includes

- A room-by-room visual assessment
- Moisture readings on plasterboard, timber, skirting and subfloor where accessible
- Humidity and temperature readings, the invisible driver
- Dated photographs
- A written report. At DrySafe, it's issued the same business day as attendance.

What the report gives you

- The affected areas and their extent
- The readings, room by room
- A scope of works and options
- A firm price the owner can approve before any works start

When to order an assessment on its own

- The cause is disputed between tenant and owner
- The owner wants evidence before spending on works
- Strata or common property may be involved
- The tenant has raised a rent reduction or compensation

How to read the report

- 1 Extent: which rooms, which surfaces, how much
- 2 Readings: where moisture is elevated
- 3 Scope: what will be done, in what order
- 4 Exclusions: what sits outside the scope, usually the source fix

Numbers are harder to argue with than photos. The tenant sees action, the owner sees evidence, and the file has a document.

4

Remediate

Once approved

Remove, don't cover. And fix the water at the same time: remediation removes growth, but it isn't a plumber.

Why surface fixes come back

Bleach, fogging on its own and a coat of paint treat the surface. Nothing is removed and the moisture stays where it is. The growth tends to return, and the tenant calls again, less patient than the first time.

What proper remediation involves, in order

- 1 Containment and protection of the work area
- 2 HEPA vacuuming of affected surfaces
- 3 A TGA-listed antimicrobial, with the safety data sheet provided
- 4 Air filtration during works, where the scope includes it
- 5 Protection of furniture and contents
- 6 Before-and-after photographs
- 7 A post-works report for the file

The parallel track: the source fix

Whatever the readings point to, book it alongside the remediation, not after it:

- Plumber for leaks, flexi hoses and waterproofing
- Roofer or gutter clean for roof and overflow water
- Strata for common property and building envelope
- Electrician for exhaust fans that don't work or don't vent outside

Verify the contractor on paper

- ☐ IICRC Certified Firm
- ☐ Current certificate of currency for public liability
- ☐ TGA-listed products, with safety data sheets
- ☐ A written report with readings and photos
- ☐ A written workmanship guarantee, and what it covers

Straight talk on guarantees

A workmanship guarantee covers the work. If the moisture source isn't fixed, growth can return. That's physics, not a loophole, and it's why the source fix matters as much as the remediation.

5

Review

After the works

The works are done. These steps close the file and set up the next inspection.

File the post-works report

Keep it with the before-and-after photos.

Confirm the source fix is complete

With the trade's invoice or report.

Give the tenant the prevention checklist

And keep a signed copy on file.

Diarise a follow-up check

At the next routine inspection.

Add these to every routine inspection

- ☐ Behind wardrobes and beds on external walls
- ☐ Ceilings below roofs and upstairs bathrooms
- ☐ Under sinks and around toilets
- ☐ Bathroom ceilings, sealant and grout
- ☐ Window frames, tracks and sills
- ☐ Exhaust fans: working, used and venting outside

The owner conversation

Present the report and the options. Explain the cost of delay in plain terms: left unaddressed, a mould problem can lead to rent reductions, a vacancy and a harder conversation at the next lease.

The mould file: what to keep

We recommend including the following in your file for completeness, in case the matter ever reaches NCAT, an insurer or a new owner.

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Date and time of the first report | ☐ Trade reports and invoices for the source fix |
| ☐ Your written acknowledgement | ☐ Assessment report with readings |
| ☐ Photos from the tenant and from you, dated | ☐ Remediation scope, approval and post-works report |
| ☐ Answers to the triage questions | ☐ Signed tenant prevention checklist |
| ☐ Ingoing condition report and inspection notes | ☐ Follow-up inspection notes |
| ☐ Owner briefings and written instructions | |

Get a quote in under 30 seconds

DrySafe Response Group works with property managers on mould assessment and remediation.

- Request through the Property Manager Priority Portal
- Attendance within 1–3 business days of approval
- Written report the same business day as attendance
- IICRC Certified Firm, \$20 million public liability
- TGA-listed antimicrobial, safety data sheet provided



Scan for the portal

✉ pm.support@drysafe.sydney

🌐 mould.drysafe.sydney/pm-portal

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